



Seed Swap Hosting Kit

Everything you need to run a community seed swap

\$10

Open-pollinated • Community-grown • Food sovereignty for everyone

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Everything You Need to Run a Community Seed Swap

Seedwarden | seedwarden.com

Seeds are meant to move. This kit helps you make that happen.

Important Notice

This kit is educational content designed to help you organize a community event. Your experience will vary depending on your venue, community, and local context. It is not professional event planning or legal advice. If your event involves a public venue, food, or minors, check with your venue and local regulations as needed.

Introduction: Why Seed Swaps Matter

A seed swap isn't a complicated event. At its core, it's a table, some envelopes, and a group of people who grew something and want to share it. But it does a few things at once that are worth naming:

It keeps heirloom and open-pollinated varieties in circulation. Seeds that aren't swapped get forgotten, and varieties that get forgotten disappear. Every exchange is an act of preservation.

It builds the kind of community that food sovereignty actually depends on — the kind where people know each other, share knowledge, and make the local food system a little more resilient.

And it's a genuinely good time. People who grow food love to talk about it.

This kit gives you the materials to run a seed swap well — whether you're hosting 15 people in a library meeting room or 200 at a community fair. The materials here are reproducible: print as many copies as you need.

Part 1: Event Planning Checklist

4–8 Weeks Out

- [] Choose a date. Saturday or Sunday morning/early afternoon works well for most communities. Avoid holiday weekends.
- [] Book your venue. See venue notes below.
- [] Set a geographic scope. Are you inviting your neighborhood? Your city? A specific gardening club or library patron base?
- [] Decide on format: free swap only, or also include a seed library component (where unclaimed seeds are held for future lending)?
- [] Identify 1–2 co-organizers. You'll want help with setup, registration, and the variety log table.
- [] Draft a brief event description for promotion.
- [] Set a seed donation policy: Are all seeds welcome, or do you want to focus on heirlooms/open-pollinated? Will you accept hybrid seeds? (Many swappers prefer open-pollinated only, since hybrid seeds don't reliably reproduce true to type.)

Venue Notes:

Good options: library meeting rooms (often free), community centers, garden center back rooms, church fellowship halls, school cafeterias on weekends. Look for a space with tables, parking, and good natural light if possible. 400–600 square feet is comfortable for 30–50 people; scale up from there.

2–4 Weeks Out

- ☐ Begin promotion. See flyer template in Part 2.
- ☐ Post in local Facebook groups, neighborhood apps (Nextdoor), community bulletin boards, library newsletters, local gardening clubs
- ☐ Contact local Master Gardeners, community garden groups, seed libraries — they're natural audiences and will help spread the word
- ☐ Email any local small farms or seed companies who might want to donate seeds or be present
- ☐ Print and post paper flyers (coffee shops, libraries, community centers, laundromats, food co-ops)
- ☐ Prepare your supply list (see below)
- ☐ Confirm the venue again in writing
- ☐ Create a simple RSVP or interest form if you want to track attendance (not required, but useful for planning)

Supply List:

- ☐ Seed packet envelopes (print from this kit, or buy small coin envelopes — #1 or #2 size)
 - ☐ Pens, markers, tape
 - ☐ Variety log sheets (print from this kit)
 - ☐ Name tags
 - ☐ Tables — at minimum 2–3: one registration/drop-off, one for swapping organized by category, one for unclaimed/bulk seeds
 - ☐ Labels or tent cards for table organization (e.g., "TOMATOES," "HERBS," "FLOWERS," "LEGUMES," "GREENS," "ROOT CROPS")
 - ☐ Bowls, trays, or small bins for organizing seeds on the swap table
 - ☐ Optional: a small scale for seed donations in bulk
 - ☐ Optional: printed "How to Describe Your Seeds" guide (Part 5 of this kit) for donors who show up without labeled packets
 - ☐ Optional: guest sign-in sheet
-

1 Week Out

- ☐ Confirm co-organizer roles and arrival time
 - ☐ Print all materials: flyers, envelopes, variety logs, description guides
 - ☐ Gather supplies
 - ☐ Send a reminder to anyone who RSVPed
 - ☐ Reach out to a few committed growers in your network to confirm they'll bring seeds — having a solid seed table matters for the first event
 - ☐ Plan the table layout on paper before you arrive
-

Day Before

- ☐ Prepare your own seed donations if you're contributing
 - ☐ Pack all supplies in one bag/box
 - ☐ Confirm venue access time with contact person
 - ☐ Charge your phone (you'll want photos)
 - ☐ Rest. Tomorrow is a good day.
-

Day of Setup (Arrive 45–60 Minutes Early)

- ☐ Set up tables per your layout
 - ☐ Label tables by category (TOMATOES, HERBS, etc.)
 - ☐ Put out pens and extra envelopes at the drop-off table
 - ☐ Set out "How to Describe Your Seeds" guides at drop-off
 - ☐ Put out name tags and sign-in sheet at the door
 - ☐ Set up the variety log table
 - ☐ Place a volunteer or co-organizer at drop-off to help donors label packets if needed
 - ☐ Open doors on time
-

During the Event

- ☐ Greet people at the door. It sounds basic, but someone at the door makes the event feel welcoming.
 - ☐ Staff the drop-off table for at least the first 30 minutes — donors often need help labeling
 - ☐ Keep variety log updated as seeds arrive
 - ☐ Announce any special donations or highlights
 - ☐ Facilitate informal introductions when you see two people who should meet
 - ☐ 15 minutes before close, announce that unclaimed seeds will go to the seed library (or be distributed free)
 - ☐ At close, collect all leftover labeled seeds for the library or next swap
-

Breakdown

- [] Collect and organize unclaimed seeds
- [] Thank and dismiss volunteers
- [] Return venue to original condition
- [] Take remaining supplies home for next time

Part 2: Event Flyer Template

Print this page, fill in your details, and make copies. Or use it as a guide to make your own.

+-----+

- -

- SEED SWAP -

- -

- Grow something. Share something. -

- -

+-----+

- -

- DATE: ----- -

- -

- TIME: ----- -

- -

- WHERE: ----- -

- ----- -

- -

+-----+

- -

- BRING seeds to share — vegetables, herbs, flowers, -

- or anything you've grown and saved. -

- -

- TAKE seeds home — varieties you've never tried before. -

- -

- No experience required. Everyone is welcome. -

- -

+-----+

- -

- Seeds to bring: open-pollinated / heirloom preferred. -

- Please label your packets with variety name and year saved. -

- Envelopes and pens available at the door. -

- -

- Questions? ----- -

- -
- Hosted by: _____ -
- -
+-----+

Design notes for your own version: Keep the flyer simple and high-contrast. "SEED SWAP" in large type does most of the work. A simple illustration of seeds or a vegetable (any clip-art or hand drawing works) adds warmth. Post in portrait orientation for bulletin boards; rotate to landscape for table handouts.

Part 3: Seed Packet Envelope Template

Print on card stock for best results. Score fold lines before folding. Each sheet can yield 2–4 envelopes depending on size.

Seed Packet — Print, Cut, and Fold

+-----+

- +=====+

- - - -

- - VARIETY: _____ - -

- - - -

- - YEAR SAVED: _____ - -

- - - -

- - GROWER: _____ - -

- - - -

- - DAYS TO MATURITY: _____ - -

- - - -

- - OPEN-POLLINATED / HEIRLOOM / OTHER - -

- - (circle one) - -

- - - -

- +=====+

- - - -

- - NOTES: - -

- - _____ - -

- - _____ - -

- - _____ - -

- - _____ - -

- - - -

- +=====+

- ←fold fold→ -

+-----+

Fold lines on the left and right sides.

Tuck flap closed or seal with a small piece of tape.

What to Write in "Notes"

The notes field is the most valuable part of the envelope. Encourage donors to fill it in. Good notes include:

- Flavor/use: "Sweet, low acid, great for fresh eating." / "Dries well, good for salsa."
- Growing tips: "Needs staking." / "Start indoors 8 weeks early." / "Very prolific — give it space."
- Disease resistance: "Held up well in our humid summers." / "Some resistance to late blight."
- Seed viability note: "Tested: 9/10 germinated" or "Older stock — sow thickly."
- Story/provenance: "Family seed, 30+ years." / "Got this from the 2022 Portland seed swap."

Brief is fine. Something is always better than nothing.

Part 4: Variety Log Sheet

Print multiple copies. One sheet holds approximately 20 variety entries. Use one sheet per category (Tomatoes, Peppers, etc.) at large events.

SEED SWAP VARIETY LOG					
Event: _____ Date: _____ Category: _____					
#	VARIETY NAME	GROWER	YR SAVED	QTY BROUGHT	NOTES / DESCRIPTION
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					

-10 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
-11 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
-12 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
-13 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
-14 -	-	-	-	-	-
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-15 -	-	-	-	-	-
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-16 -	-	-	-	-	-
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-17 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
-18 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
-19 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
-20 -	-	-	-	-	-
+-----+-----+-----+-----+					

NOTES: _____

How to use the variety log:

Assign one volunteer to manage the log table. As donors bring seeds, the volunteer records the variety, grower, year saved, and approximate quantity. This serves two purposes: it creates a record for your community's seed library, and it helps you track which varieties are popular (the ones that disappear fastest at a swap are worth growing more of).

At large events, use separate log sheets per category — one for Tomatoes, one for Herbs, etc. This makes the table easier to manage and the records easier to archive.

Part 5: How to Describe Your Seeds — Donor Guide

Print this as a single page and place it at the drop-off table. It helps new seed savers label their donations well without feeling intimidated.

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-

- HOW TO DESCRIBE YOUR SEEDS -
- A guide for first-time seed donors -
- -
- +-----+

You grew it. You saved it. That's the hard part.

Now you just need to help the next grower know what they're getting. Here's what to write on your packet:

The basics (required):

Variety name: What's it called? If you saved it from a named variety, use that name. If it's a family seed without a formal name, you can call it "Grandma Rose's tomato" or "our red paste" — that's legitimate and more meaningful than a catalog name.

Year saved: The year you collected these seeds. Seeds generally stay viable 2–5 years depending on the crop. Recent is better, but older seeds that were stored well can still be viable — just say so and suggest sowing thickly.

Your name or initials: So people can find you if they have questions, and to build community — seeds with a face behind them matter more.

Days to maturity: If you know it, write it. If not, an approximation is fine ("about 75 days from transplant").

The good stuff (optional but appreciated):

What does it taste like? Sweet, tangy, rich, mild, spicy, bitter, nutty — even one word helps. "Best tomato I've ever grown" is not specific but still useful.

Any quirks? Needs staking? Sprawling habit? Tends to bolt in heat? Needs hand-pollination? Takes longer than expected? These are things you'd want to know, and so would the next grower.

How did it do for you? Disease problems? Thrived in containers? Produced late into fall? Any observation from your actual growing experience is valuable.

Where did the seeds come from originally? Did you get them at a seed swap? Buy them from a small company? Inherit them? This provenance matters — it's part of the variety's story.

A note on hybrids:

If your seeds came from a hybrid variety (anything labeled F1 in a catalog), the seeds may not grow true to type. This is okay to bring — just write "F1 hybrid, seeds may vary" on the packet. Some people actively want hybrid seeds; they just need to know what they're getting.

Open-pollinated and heirloom seeds will grow true to type (assuming reasonable isolation during seed saving), and these are the backbone of seed swaps.

Don't have a labeled packet?

That's fine. Envelopes and pens are at the drop-off table. Our volunteers can help you fill out a packet if you're not sure what to write. You don't need to have it perfectly labeled before you arrive.

Thank you for bringing seeds. This is how varieties stay alive.

Part 6: Post-Event Follow-Up Checklist

A good seed swap creates momentum. Here's how to follow through.

Within 48 Hours

- ☐ Write a brief thank-you to your venue contact
 - ☐ Send a thank-you message to volunteers
 - ☐ Sort and store any unclaimed seeds from the swap (for seed library or next event)
 - ☐ Note approximate attendance and variety count
 - ☐ Capture any feedback or comments while they're fresh
-

Within 1 Week

- [] Post a brief recap to whatever community channels you used for promotion: "We had 40 people share 75 varieties — thank you!" This closes the loop, builds the brand for next year, and thanks people who couldn't make it.
 - [] Share any photos (with permission of people in them)
 - [] Add new varieties to your seed library catalog if you're maintaining one
 - [] Note which categories were well-represented and which had gaps (you'll want to recruit donors for the gaps next time)
-

For Next Time

- [] Write down what worked and what you'd do differently while it's fresh
 - [] Note the 3 most popular varieties (the ones that went fastest) — these are worth growing yourself and bringing double next year
 - [] Consider whether you want to add any new elements: a speaker, a seed-saving demonstration, a seed library, a kids' table
 - [] Set a tentative date for the next swap while you have energy and goodwill from this one
 - [] Build your contact list — everyone who signed in is a potential returning donor, volunteer, and community member
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Growing the Event Year Over Year

The first seed swap in a community is always the smallest. The second is bigger because the first built trust. A few things that help events grow:

Continuity: Same time of year builds habit. Late winter or early spring (February–March) works well — it's when growers are thinking about seeds.

Documentation: The variety log creates a record that becomes an asset. A community that knows it swapped Cherokee Purple tomatoes and Speckled Roman paste and Lemon Boy in 2023 has a story to build on.

Invitation culture: Seed swaps grow through personal invitation more than mass promotion. "You should come — you'll love it" matters more than a flyer.

Welcome new growers: Every event should feel accessible to someone who has never grown anything. One "How to Start Growing" table with some basic resources and a few seeds labeled "easy for beginners" makes a real difference.

Seeds move from hand to hand. That's how they've always moved. This event is part of something that goes back a long time — people sharing what they grew with people who want to grow it. You're just organizing the table.

— Seedwarden

seedwarden.com | Questions? Reach us through our Etsy shop.

This kit may be printed for personal, community, and library use. Please do not redistribute digitally or resell. We'd love to hear about your swap — tag us or drop a note through the shop.

More from Seedwarden

If you found this guide useful, you might also like:

- Food Sovereignty Starter Guide (\$8) — Give swap attendees the full picture on growing, saving, and sharing seeds
- Seed Saving Field Manual (\$14) — The technical reference behind every packet you bring to the table
- Anti-Catalog: 30 Heirlooms Worth Growing (\$10) — Curated variety profiles to spark conversation at your next swap

Browse all Seedwarden guides at [our Etsy shop].